

Measuring CSR: A Menu of Options



The Scenario

Patrick Stocks was the national marketing manager for the South African arm of Deluxe Chicken, a market-leading multinational fast-food chain that sells fried chicken. As of December 2024, the company had 40 locations in South Africa and served a broad range of customers of all ages. Patrick was tasked with managing brand and purpose, including corporate social responsibility (CSR) initiatives for the company's South African market. In early January 2025, Patrick sat down with his manager, Stephenie Ndlovu, for one of their regularly scheduled status meetings.

Fast Facts: Deluxe Chicken

- **Industry:** Food service
- **Worldwide employees:** 165,000
- **Employees in South Africa:** 12,000
- **Restaurants in South Africa:** 40

The Conversation

Stephanie: We've been focused on expansion plans lately, but today I want to catch up on how our CSR efforts are going. One of our projects is a scholarship fund for college students, and the other is food donations for various children's groups. How are those progressing?

Patrick: Good, each initiative has about USD \$150,000 budgeted over three years.

Stephanie: Let's drill down on the food program.

Patrick: We donate funds to partner organizations—early childhood development centers, children's homes, schools—to provide meals to children who would otherwise not get the nutrition they need.

Stephanie: Are we donating Deluxe Chicken brand products, too?

Patrick: No, the fact that we mainly make fried chicken complicates that direct donation because it's not the healthiest option.

Stephanie: I've heard that the food donations have helped our brand and reputation though, right?

Patrick: We've had some small mentions in local and regional press via their social media channels. They have applauded how our CSR efforts show our commitment to the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals. We've shared that news on LinkedIn, and some posts get a lot of positive attention.

Stephanie: That's good. Do we know more about how that attention affects the bottom line? Do you have other numbers about impact?

Patrick: I'll do some research.

Stephanie: Great. I'm curious to know more, although I'm glad things seem positive. I'm asking this mainly because a sports sponsorship agency reached out to me. They have another sponsorship possibility for Deluxe called Soccer4Good. One of their clients—actually, one of our competitors, Quick Pies—has been supporting an initiative called Soccer4Good. Quick Pies is moving on to another CSR initiative. Here are some notes the agency shared with me:

- Soccer4Good is a South Africa-based organization that has grown steadily over the last few years.
- Last year, 32,000 children, ages six to 12, were enrolled to learn soccer skills and play matches, with 2,500 volunteer coaches.
- Soccer4Good partners with schools and communities to use spaces for games.
- Communities with no formal school sports activities are given first priority.
- Positive results included improvement in the children's communication, teamwork, accountability, and resilience.

Patrick: Intriguing. I'll look at this and come back with some more information for you.

The Follow-Up Conversation

Two weeks later, Patrick and Stephanie met again.

Stephanie: An international consultant is helping Deluxe Chicken locations in each country create more refined measurements around impact related to spend, especially marketing. We need to come up with a proposal for her (if we think we should put this new sponsorship to the board) for how we would measure impact.

Patrick: Soccer4Good does not measure impact very precisely, apart from, perhaps, the number of children involved. However, they do think that it really makes a difference in the children's lives.

Stephanie: All the logistics would be covered by the sports marketing agency, correct?

Patrick: That's right. We'd need to coordinate with the sports marketing agency, but it wouldn't require time from any of our other full-time staff. I think it will take a few days a year for us to look at the overall plan, plus minimal time throughout the year to review messaging, progress, and metrics.

Stephanie: Can you draft something about this sponsorship so we can discuss this with the consultant? If we're going to spend around USD \$150,000 over three years, we need to think about the why and be clear about both the time and financial investment. Why would we recommend this? What would we use to measure impact for the kids involved in the program, as well as the positive outcomes for our business?

The Ask

1. What points should Patrick include in the proposal?
2. How would any results be tracked and measured?

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